

What Make Employees Committed? Exploring the Relationships Between
Perceptions of Justice, Organizational Commitment, and Personality

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INTRODUCTION

Research has shown that employees with high levels of commitment bestow a wide range of organizational benefits including higher performance, lower turnover, and employees being more likely to go “above and beyond” in their role (Hafiz, 2017). Many companies strive to cultivate commitment among employees but the antecedents to commitment can be unclear. Studies providing insight into this problem have found a link between high levels of organizational commitment and equitable treatment perceived by employees, or high levels of perceived organizational justice (Bakhshi, Kumar, & Rani, 2009; Estreder, Tomas, Chambel, & Ramos, 2019). Historically, organizational justice has been studied as differing facets – distributive justice, procedural justice, interactional justice, and informational justice. However, for the purposes of this study, examining fairness in organizations may be better served by using an overall measure of justice as the effects of justice can become understated when separated into facets (Hauenstein, McGonigle, & Flinder, 2001). Indeed, using overall justice to understand organizational commitment makes intuitive sense as individuals generally perceive justice in a holistic manner (Jones & Martens, 2009). Similarly, when individuals experience injustice, they react to general feelings of injustice as opposed to specific facets of injustice (Shapiro, 2001). Thus, the present study examines organizational commitment utilizing an overall model of justice proposed by Ambrose & Schminke (2009). Organizational commitment was studied through the commonly used three part framework of affective commitment, continuance commitment, and normative commitment (Allen & Meyer 1990). Affective commitment considers the employee’s emotional attachment to an organization, continuance commitment considers the employee’s perceived costs associated with leaving an organization, and normative commitment considers the employee’s sense of duty or obligation to an organization. Allen &

Meyer summarized their framework by stating that affective commitment exists when an individual “wants to stay” with a company, continuance commitment exists when an individual “has to stay” with a company, and normative commitment exists when an individual “ought to stay” with a company. In accordance with past trends in justice and organizational commitment research, this study expects that employee perceptions of justice will influence organizational commitment:

Hypothesis 1: Participants experiencing higher levels of overall justice will display significantly higher levels of affective commitment, continuance commitment, and normative commitment.

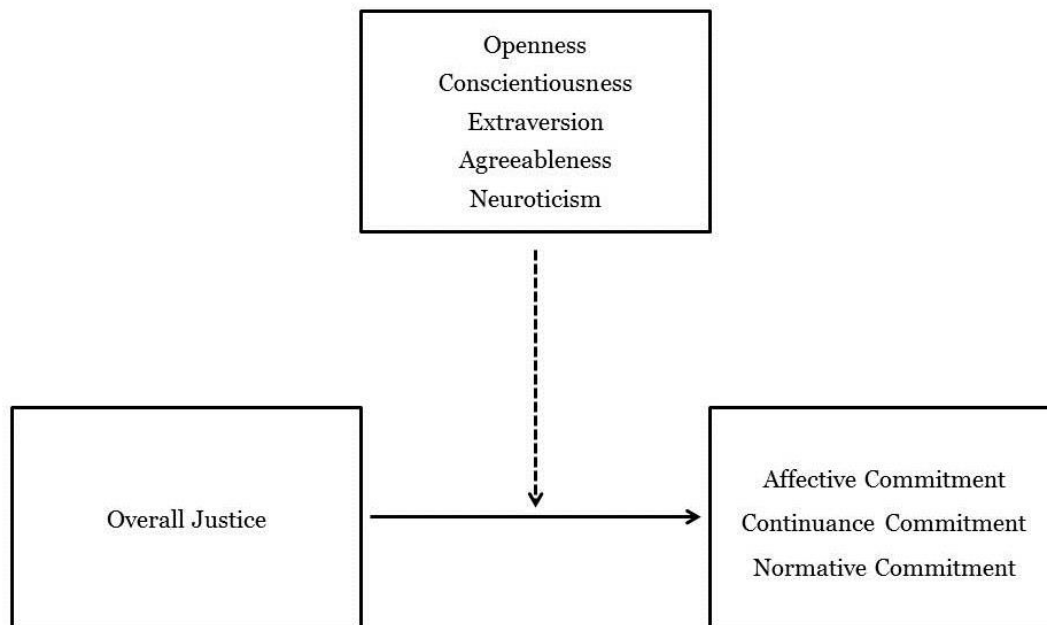
An examination of organizational commitment based solely on justice perceptions may be deficient as individual differences can be a potentially large source of variance. Perceptions of justice are subjective since individuals may uniquely perceive equity experiences despite identical conditions. Such variation in individual perception may be due to differences in personality. Research on personality has generally been studied using the widely accepted Big Five model of personality traits which posits that personality is comprised of five factors – Openness, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Neuroticism (John, Naumann, & Soto, 2008). Openness is characterized by imagination and insight, Conscientiousness is characterized by good impulse control and goal-directed behaviors, Extraversion is characterized by a strong desire to engage in social situations, Agreeableness is characterized by trust and kindness, and Neuroticism is characterized by emotional instability and moodiness. While there has been a fair amount of research investigating the relationship between personality and organizational commitment, there is a dearth of research on how personality affects the relationship between justice and organizational commitment. Research on justice and

organizational citizenship behaviors found moderating effects of Extraversion, Conscientiousness, and Openness (Golparvar & Javadian, 2012). Skarlicki, Folger, & Tesluk (1999) also found moderating effects for Neuroticism and Agreeableness on justice and workplace retaliation. The present study aims to contribute to the current literature by investigating the relationship between perceptions of justice and organizational commitment and exploring if personality plays a role in this relationship:

Hypothesis 2: The effect of overall justice on organizational commitment will be moderated by changes in the Big Five personality factors of Openness, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Neuroticism.

Figure 1

Theoretical Model for Hypothesis 2



Note. Organizational commitment as a function of Overall Justice moderated by the Big Five Personality traits.

METHOD

This study was conducted via an online survey on participants who were currently or previously employed full-time or part-time. Items on the survey corresponded to three measures – overall justice, organizational commitment, and personality. The overall justice measure was unidimensional, the organizational commitment measure had three dimensions (affective, continuance, normative), and the personality measure had five dimensions (Openness, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Neuroticism). All items were rated by respondents on a scale of 1-5 with higher values indicating higher levels of the measure. Participation in the survey was entirely voluntary and respondents were not compensated.

Participants

The survey was sent out to 137 people who initially completed the survey; however, after data cleaning – removing incomplete responses – the final number of respondents was 104. Post data cleaning, the final sample was 47% female, 50% male, and 3% identified as neither female nor male with a median age of 25 – 34. The highest level of education completed for the final sample respondents was 27% high school, 56% bachelor degrees, 13% master's degrees, and 3% doctorate degrees. The ethnicity of the final sample respondents was 42% White, 8% Hispanic, 45% Asian, and 5% Black.

Measuring Overall Justice

In order to assess respondents' perceptions of fair treatment by their organization, the Overall Justice scale developed by Ambrose & Schminke (2009) was utilized. This scale was developed to capture an overall meaning of justice encompassing different theories of organizational justice such as distributive, procedural, and interactional justice (Ambrose &

Schminke, 2009). It includes three items which identifies respondent's personal experiences of overall justice such as, "Overall, I'm treated fairly by my organization" (See Appendix 1 for a complete list of items). The scale also included three items which seeks to identify the fairness of the organization generally such as, "For the most part, this organization treats its employees fairly." The items on this scale were rated by respondents on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neither agree nor disagree, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly agree) with higher values indicating stronger employee perceptions of fair treatment by their respective organization. The scores from the items in the scale were averaged together to form a score of Overall Justice. The average Overall Justice score within the sample was 3.33 ($SD = 1.05$). Research by Ambrose & Schminke (2009) for the Overall Justice scale found a reliability of .93. The present study found a reliability coefficient of .96 for the Overall Justice scale calculated using Cronbach's alpha, a measure of internal consistency. An overview of these descriptive statistics can be found in Table 1.

Table 1

Scale Descriptives (N = 104)

Survey scale	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	α	Original scale α
Overall Justice	3.33	1.05	.96	.93
Affective Commitment	2.88	1.06	.88	.86
Continuance Commitment	2.93	.95	.67	.82
Normative Commitment	2.73	.92	.68	.73
BFI-S Openness	3.83	.86	.70	.58
BFI-S Conscientiousness	3.54	.67	.48	.60
BFI-S Extraversion	2.83	.95	.77	.76
BFI-S Agreeableness	3.66	.73	.51	.44
BFI-S Neuroticism	3.29	.90	.78	.66

Note. Original scale α displays reliabilities of the original scales adapted for this study.

Measuring Organizational Commitment

In order to assess respondents' levels of organizational commitment, adapted versions of the scales for organizational commitment by Allen & Meyer (1990) were utilized. Allen & Meyer utilized a three-component model of organizational commitment which separated organizational commitment into affective commitment, continuance commitment, and normative commitment. Allen & Meyer's original scale for each component of organizational commitment consisted of six items. To maintain survey brevity and reduce respondent fatigue, the top three items with the highest factor loadings for each component were chosen for this study. The scale for affective commitment consisted of three items such as, "I feel a strong sense of belonging to my organization" (See Appendix 1 for a complete list of items). The scale for continuance commitment consisted of three items such as, "It would be very hard for me to leave my organization right now, even if I wanted to." The scale for normative commitment consisted of three items such as, "This organization deserves my loyalty." The items on this scale were rated by respondents on a 5-point Likert scale (1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neither agree nor disagree, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly agree) with higher values indicating higher levels of organizational commitment. Item scores from each scale were averaged together to form an overall score for that scale. The average Affective Commitment score within the sample was 2.88 ($SD = 1.06$). The average Continuance Commitment score within the sample was 2.93 ($SD = 0.95$). The average Normative Commitment score within the sample was 2.73 ($SD = .92$). Research by Allen & Meyer (1990) for the overall justice scale found a reliability of .86 for the Affective Commitment scale, a reliability of .82 for the Continuance Commitment scale, and a reliability of .73 for the Normative Commitment scale. The present study found a reliability of .88 for the Affective Commitment scale, a reliability of .67 for the Continuance Commitment

scale, and a reliability of .68 for the Normative Commitment scale using Cronbach's alpha, a measure of internal consistency. An overview of these descriptive statistics can be found in Table 1.

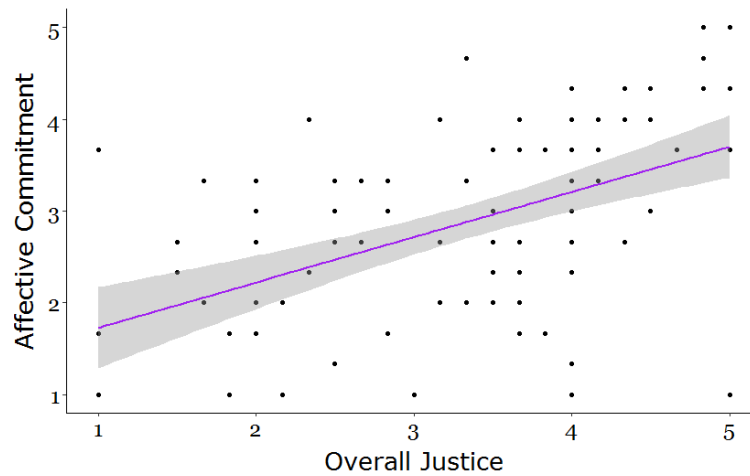
Measuring Personality

In order to assess respondents' personality traits, the Big Five Inventory - Short Form (BFI-S) was utilized. The BFI-S contained scales consisting of three items for each of the five personality traits: openness, conscientiousness, extraversion, agreeableness, and neuroticism. Openness included three items such as, "I see myself as someone who is original, comes up with new ideas" (See Appendix 1 for a complete list of items). Conscientiousness included three items such as, "I see myself as someone who does a thorough job." Extraversion included three items such as, "I see myself as someone who is talkative." Agreeableness included three items such as, "I see myself as someone who is considerate and kind to almost everyone." Neuroticism included three items such as, "I see myself as someone who worries a lot." The items on this scale were rated by respondents on a 5 point Likert scale (1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neither agree nor disagree, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly agree) with higher numbers indicating higher levels of the personality trait. Item scores from each scale were averaged together to form an overall score for that scale. The average Openness score within the sample was 3.83 ($SD = .86$). The average Conscientiousness score within the sample was 3.54 ($SD = .67$). The average Extraversion score within the sample was 2.83 ($SD = .95$). The average Agreeableness score within the sample was 3.66 ($SD = .73$). The average Neuroticism score within the sample was 3.29 ($SD = .90$). Research by Hahn, Gottschling, and Spinath (2012) on the BFI-S found a reliability of .58 for the Openness scale, a reliability of .60 for the Conscientiousness scale, a reliability of .76 for the Extraversion scale, a reliability of .44 for the Agreeableness scale, and a

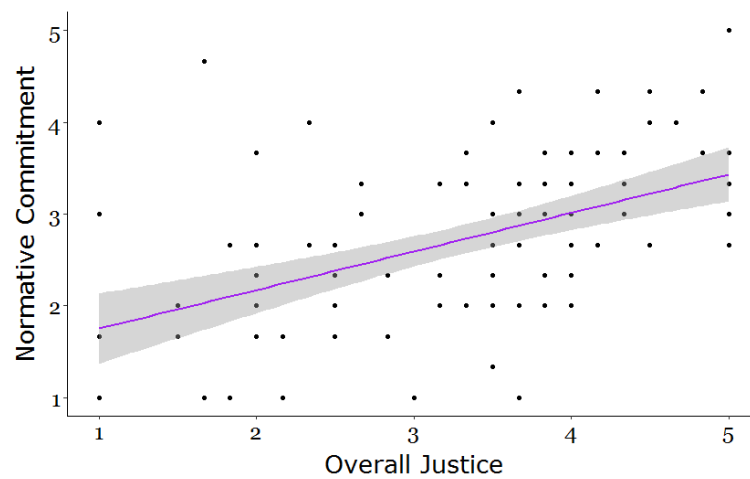
reliability of .66 for the Neuroticism scale. The present study found a reliability coefficient of .70 for the Openness scale, a reliability coefficient of .48 for the Conscientiousness scale, a reliability coefficient of .77 for Extraversion scale, a reliability coefficient of .51 for the Agreeableness scale, and a reliability coefficient of .78 for the Neuroticism scale calculated using Cronbach's alpha, a measure of internal consistency. An overview of these descriptive statistics can be found in Table 1.

RESULTS

To explore the relationship between Overall Justice and the three types of organizational commitment, a simple linear regression was calculated to predict Affective Commitment, Continuance Commitment, and Normative Commitment based on Overall Justice. Based on this analysis, Overall Justice significantly predicted Affective Commitment ($F(1,102) = 32.25, p < .001$), with an R^2 of .24 (See Figure 2). No significant relationship was found for Overall Justice and Continuance Commitment ($F(1,102) = .722, p = .398$). Overall Justice significantly predicted Normative Commitment ($F(1,102) = 30.92, p < .001$), with an R^2 of .23 (See Figure 3).

Figure 2

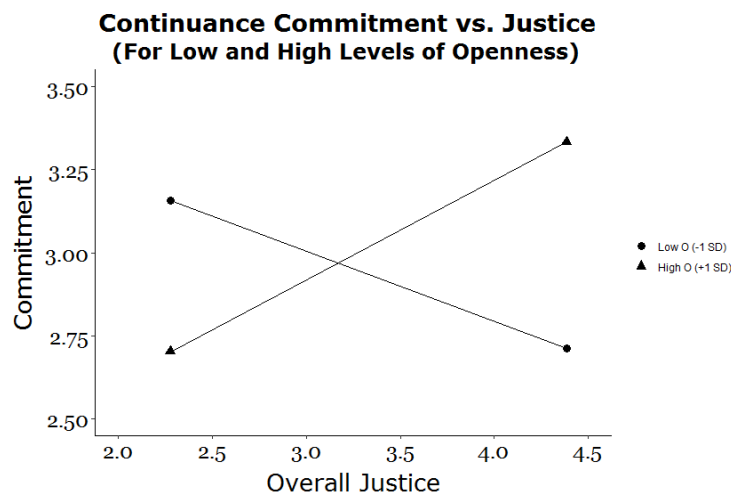
Note. A scatterplot of Affective Commitment and Overall Justice with a regression line predicting Affective Commitment based on Justice Score. Shaded gray area represents the range of error for predictions with a 95% confidence interval.

Figure 3

Note. A scatterplot of Normative Commitment and Overall Justice with a regression line predicting Normative Commitment based on Justice Score. Shaded gray area represents the range of error for predictions with a 95% confidence interval.

To explore whether personality plays a role in the relationship between Overall Justice and the three types of organizational commitment, a multiple regression was run. The model had Affective Commitment, Continuance Commitment, or Normative Commitment as the dependent variable and Overall Justice, one personality trait (Openness, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, or Neuroticism), and the interaction between Overall Justice and the personality trait as independent variables. Based on this analysis, Overall Justice and Openness along with the interaction variable significantly predicted Continuance Commitment ($F(3,100) = 3.09, p = .003$), with an R^2 of .08. The interaction term was significant ($t = 2.80, p < .01$), so a simple slopes analysis was used to determine potential moderating effects of Openness on Overall Justice and Continuance Commitment. Based on this simple slopes analysis, high Openness was found to significantly moderate Overall Justice and Continuance Commitment, $t = 2.58, p = .01$ (See Figure 4). No significant moderating effect was found for low Openness on Overall Justice and Continuance Commitment.

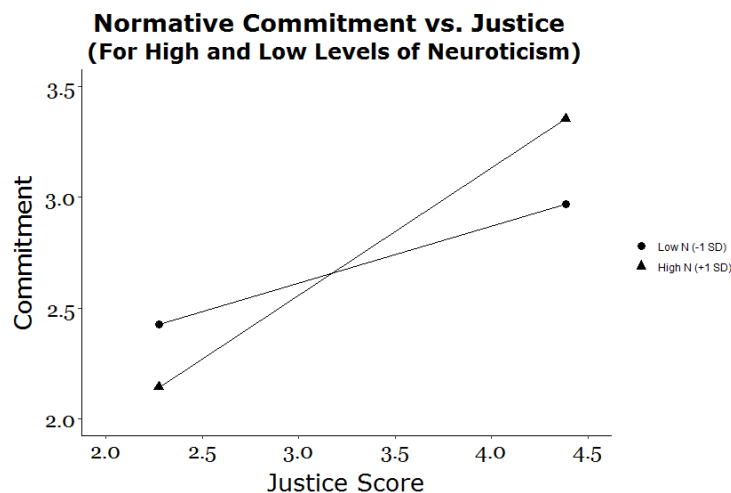
Figure 4



Note. High openness was found to significantly moderate the effect of Overall Justice on Continuance Commitment. No significant moderating effect was found for low Openness.

A multiple regression analysis with Overall Justice and Neuroticism along with the interaction variable significantly predicted Normative Commitment ($F(3,100) = 12.42, p < .001$), with an R^2 of .27. The interaction term was significant ($t = 2.30, p = .02$), so a simple slopes analysis was used to determine potential moderating effects of Neuroticism on Overall Justice and Normative Commitment. Based on this simple slopes analysis, low Neuroticism was found to significantly moderate Overall Justice and Normative Commitment, $t = 2.53, p = .01$. High Neuroticism was also found to significantly moderate Overall Justice and Normative Commitment, $t = 5.73, p < .001$ (See Figure 5).

Figure 5



Note. High and low Neuroticism was found to significantly moderate the effect of Overall Justice on Continuance Commitment.

No significant effect of moderation was found for other combinations of dependent and independent variables using multiple regression analysis.

DISCUSSION

In the current business landscape, nurturing employee commitment has become critical for businesses to stay competitive. To explore potential antecedents for organizational commitment, the present study examined perceptions of justice using an overall justice model on organizational commitment using a three component framework for organizational commitment (affective commitment, continuance commitment, and normative commitment). Personality was also assessed using the Big Five personality traits (Openness, Conscientiousness, Extraversion, Agreeableness, and Neuroticism) to determine potential moderation on the relationship between justice and organizational commitment. Findings from the present study were consistent with past studies which found a positive relationship between justice and organizational commitment (Bakhshi, Kumar, & Rani, 2009; Estreder, Tomas, Chambel, & Ramos, 2019). Through regression analysis, the current study found perceptions of justice to be a significant predictor of affective commitment and normative commitment but not continuance Commitment. This appears reasonable as unfair treatment perceived by employees may not necessarily affect the individual's "costs" for leaving an organization, i.e., continuance commitment, since those costs are external to the employee. However, perceived unfair treatment may impact the employee's emotional connection and feelings of obligation towards the organization, i.e., affective commitment and normative commitment respectively, since those two forms of organizational commitment are more internal to the employee when compared with continuance commitment.

Interestingly, high Openness was found to have a significant moderating effect on Overall Justice and Continuance Commitment. This may suggest that individuals who are high in

openness to experience become more aware of the costs of leaving an organization when the organization treats them in a just manner. Further research is needed to explore and more fully understand this effect. Neuroticism was found to significantly moderate the relationship between Overall Justice and Normative Commitment. This finding is consistent with research by Skarlicki, Folger, & Tesluk (1999) which demonstrated that Neuroticism moderated the effects of justice on workplace retaliation. A significant moderating effect of Neuroticism suggests that individuals low in Neuroticism, i.e., individuals that are calm, are more likely to view themselves as obligated to an organization in the presence of unfair treatment. Conversely, individuals high in Neuroticism, i.e., individuals that are anxious, are more likely to view themselves as obligated to an organization in the presence of fair treatment.

No other significant moderating effects of personality were found on the relationship between justice and organizational commitment. This finding is inconsistent with past research which found moderating effects for Extraversion, Conscientiousness, and Openness on justice and organizational citizenship behaviors (Golparvar & Javadian, 2012). This inconsistency may be due to differences in dependent measures as organizational commitment was used in the present study instead of organizational citizenship. However, it is surprising that no significant moderating effect was found for Extraversion and Conscientiousness considering that current literature has identified impressive associations between Extraversion and Conscientiousness with organizational commitment (Choi, Oh, & Colbert, 2015). Despite Extraversion and Conscientiousness' strong influence as independent measures which influence organizational commitment, perhaps their roles becomes greatly diminished as moderators on justice and organizational commitment. Further research is needed to clarify these equivocal findings.

A limitation of the present study was that cultural contexts were not explored as prior research on organizational commitment found a strong interaction between personality and culture (Choi, Oh, & Colbert, 2015). Most of the participants in the sample were from individualist cultures, primarily the United States, and results in the current study may not generalize to other contexts. Such cross cultural differences may be especially relevant when examining organizational commitment in multinational corporations. Another limitation was the use of self-report in measuring overall justice, organizational commitment, and personality. Although participants were informed that surveys were anonymous, socially desirable responding may still exist. For instance, a participant may respond positively to the item “I see myself as someone who is kind and considerate to almost everyone” without actually exhibiting those behaviors.

Past research on organizational commitment focused primarily on the main effects of justice and personality in predicting organizational commitment. The current study revealed that personality can interact with perceptions of justice to develop organizational commitment. This may be relevant for organizations developing interventions to promote organizational commitment as intervention effects may vary with respect to employee Openness or Neuroticism. Presently, explorations into personality as a moderator of justice and organizational commitment are in the nascent stages of research and the author hopes that the current study provides a meaningful foundation for subsequent studies into this field.

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Appendix 1: Variable Make Up

Note: All scales were 5-point agreement scales (1 = Strongly disagree, 2 = Disagree, 3 = Neither agree nor disagree, 4 = Agree, 5 = Strongly agree)

Overall Justice

- Overall, I'm treated fairly by my organization.
- In general, I can count on this organization to be fair.
- In general, the treatment that I receive around here is fair.
- Usually, the ways things work in this organization are fair.
- For the most part, this organization treats its employees fairly.
- Most of the people who work here would say they are often treated unfairly.

Affective Commitment

- I feel a strong sense of "belonging" to my organization.
- I feel like "part of the family" at my organization.
- This organization has a great deal of personal meaning for me.

Continuance Commitment

- It would be very hard for me to leave my organization right now, even if I wanted to.
- Too much of my life would be disrupted if I decided I wanted to leave my organization now.
- I feel that I have too few options to consider leaving this organization.

Normative Commitment

- This organization deserves my loyalty.
- I owe a great deal to my organization.
- I would feel guilty if I left my organization now.

Big Five Openness

I see myself as someone who...

- is original, comes up with new ideas
- values artistic, aesthetic experiences
- has an active imagination

Big Five Conscientiousness

I see myself as someone who...

- does a thorough job
- tends to be lazy
- does things efficiently

Big Five Extraversion

I see myself as someone who...

- is talkative
- is outgoing, sociable

- is reserved

Big Five Agreeableness

I see myself as someone who...

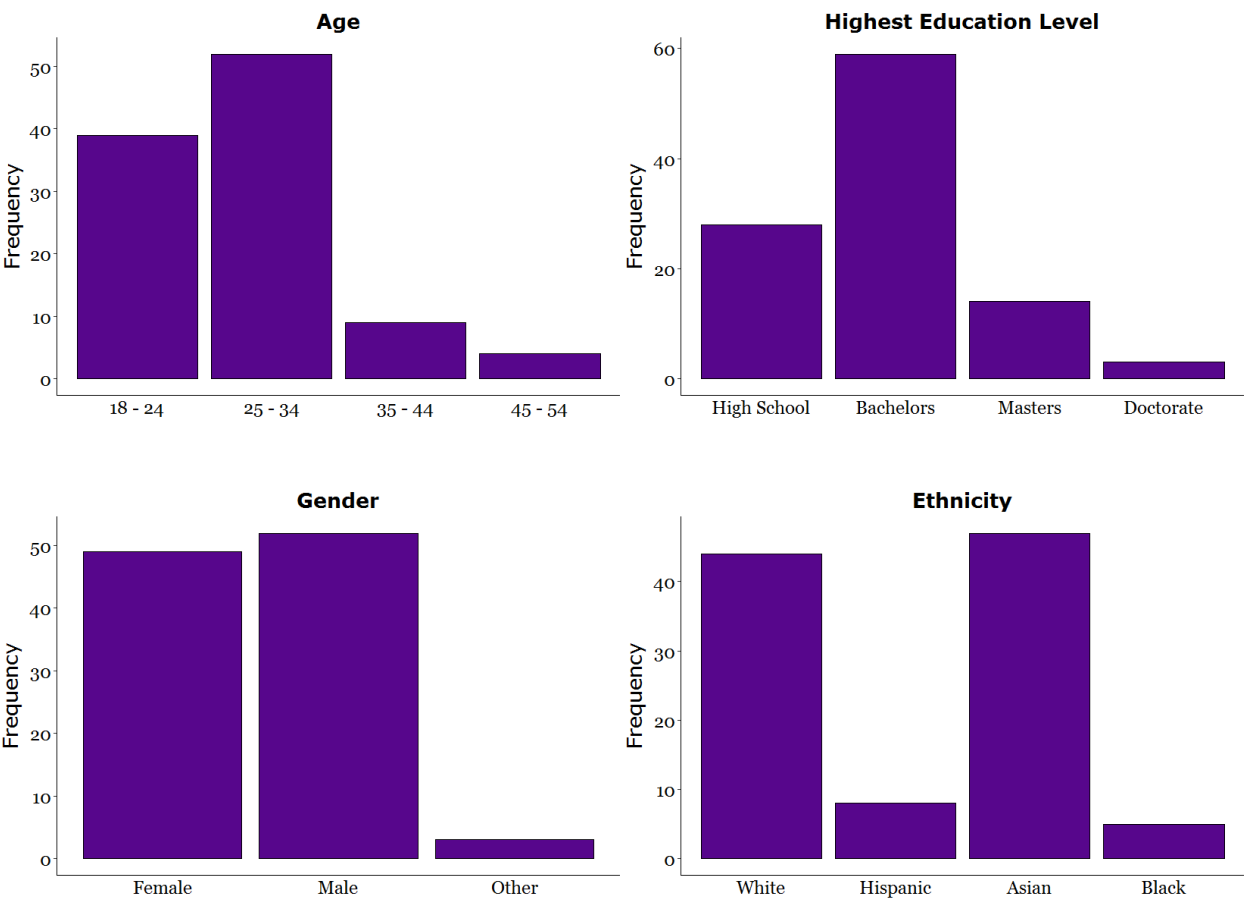
- is sometimes rude to others
- has a forgiving nature
- is considerate and kind to almost everyone

Big Five Neuroticism

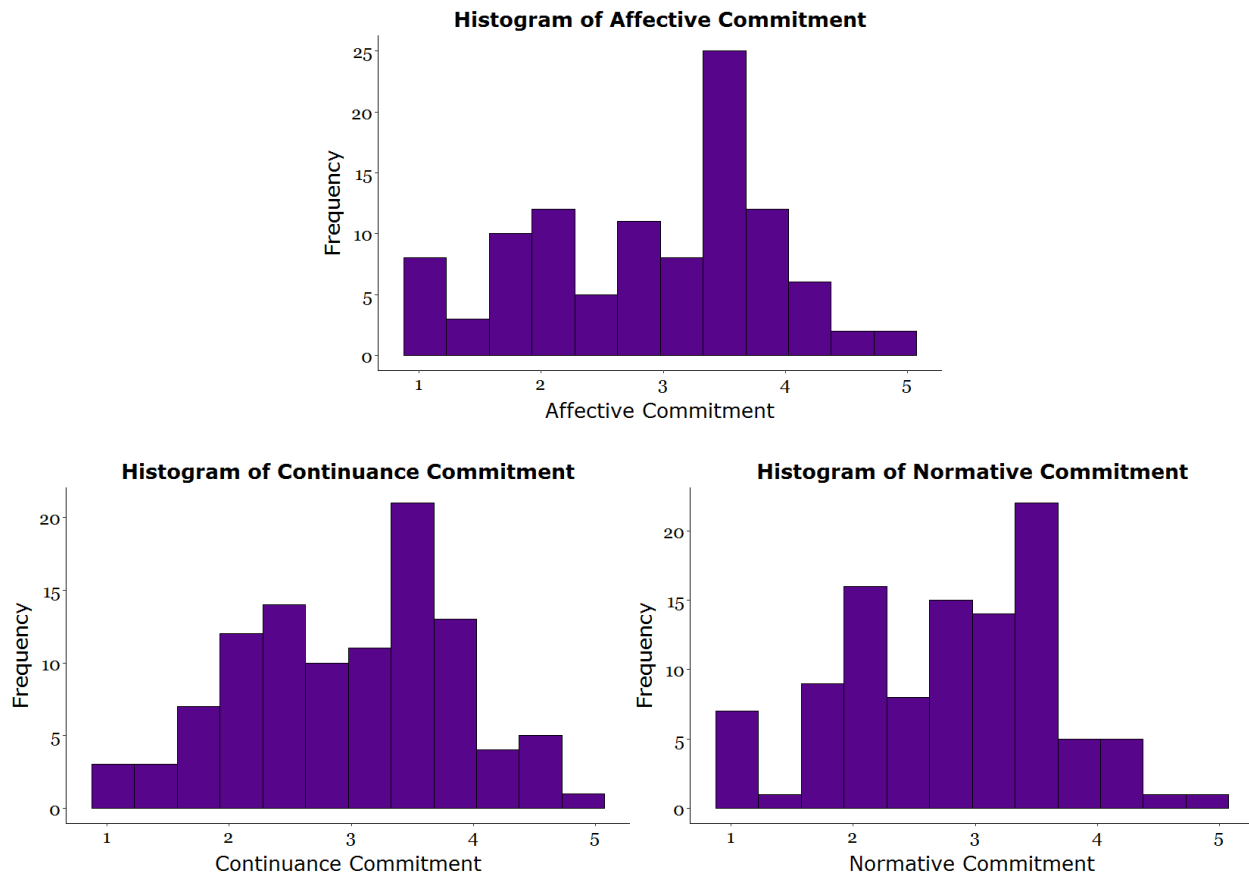
I see myself as someone who...

- worries a lot
- gets nervous easily
- remains calm in tense situations

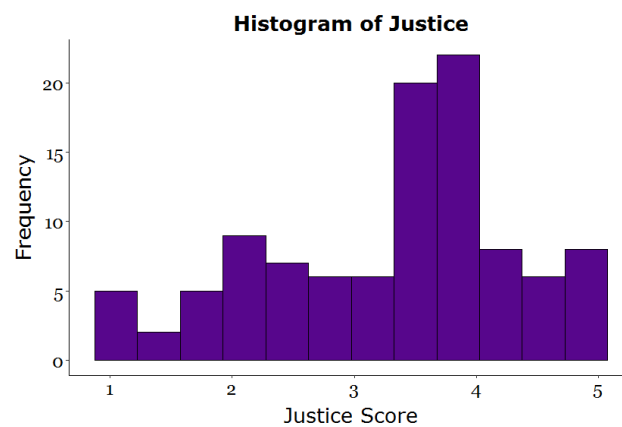
Appendix 2: Descriptive Statistics Figures



Demographic data of survey respondents



Histograms of scores for the three types of organizational commitment



Histogram of Overall Justice Score